

MORPHOLOGY & SPELLING

Upper Elementary | Unit 7

Explain the Spelling



Today I am learning to use **morphemes** and **word sums** to explain why a word is spelled the way it is.

1 Learn the Strategy

When a spelling looks tricky, look for the **base word** and the **suffix**. A word sum can show what stayed the same and what changed.

make + ing → making drop final e
run + ing → running double n
happy + ness → happiness change y to i

2 Build and Explain

Complete each word sum and name the spelling rule.

Base	Suffix	New word	What happened?
hope	-ful	_____	_____
plan	-ed	_____	_____
try	-ed	_____	_____
care	-less	_____	_____
big	-er	_____	_____

3 Read and Notice

Read the passage below.

Ella was **planning** a display for the school garden project. She had **hoped** to finish quickly, but one sign needed **making** again. She **tried** a new layout and carefully checked every label. A **helpful** friend carried the paper while Ella was **cutting** the headings. They **planned** where each card would go and decided the **bigger** title was easier to read. Ella was **happier** with the second version because the information looked clearer. Before packing up, she noticed how the spelling of each word could be explained: plan + ed became **planned**, make + ing became **making**, try + ed became **tried**, and help + ful became **helpful**. Looking at the word parts helped her see that spelling was not just something to memorise; the base word and suffix gave her clues.



Highlight four derived words. Underline the **base word** you can see inside each one.

4 Word Detective

Choose one derived word from the passage and explain its spelling.

- Write the derived word.

- What is the base word and suffix?

- Write its word sum.

- What spelling change happened - or did the base stay the same?

5 Match the Rule

Sort each word by the spelling rule it shows.

making planned tried helpful bigger careless

happiness running

Drop e	Double	y → i	Keep base
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

6 Explain in Writing



Complete the explanation.

- The word _____ comes from _____.
- I know how to spell it because...



Parent check

Tick the skills your learner has demonstrated.

- ☐ Finds the base word and suffix
- ☐ Uses a word sum to show structure
- ☐ Identifies the spelling change
- ☐ Explains why a derived word is spelled that way



Capture idea:

Choose a tricky word from a book. Write its **word sum** and explain the spelling rule you can see.